UTTAR PRADESH

SP-CONGRESS: A WIDENING GULF

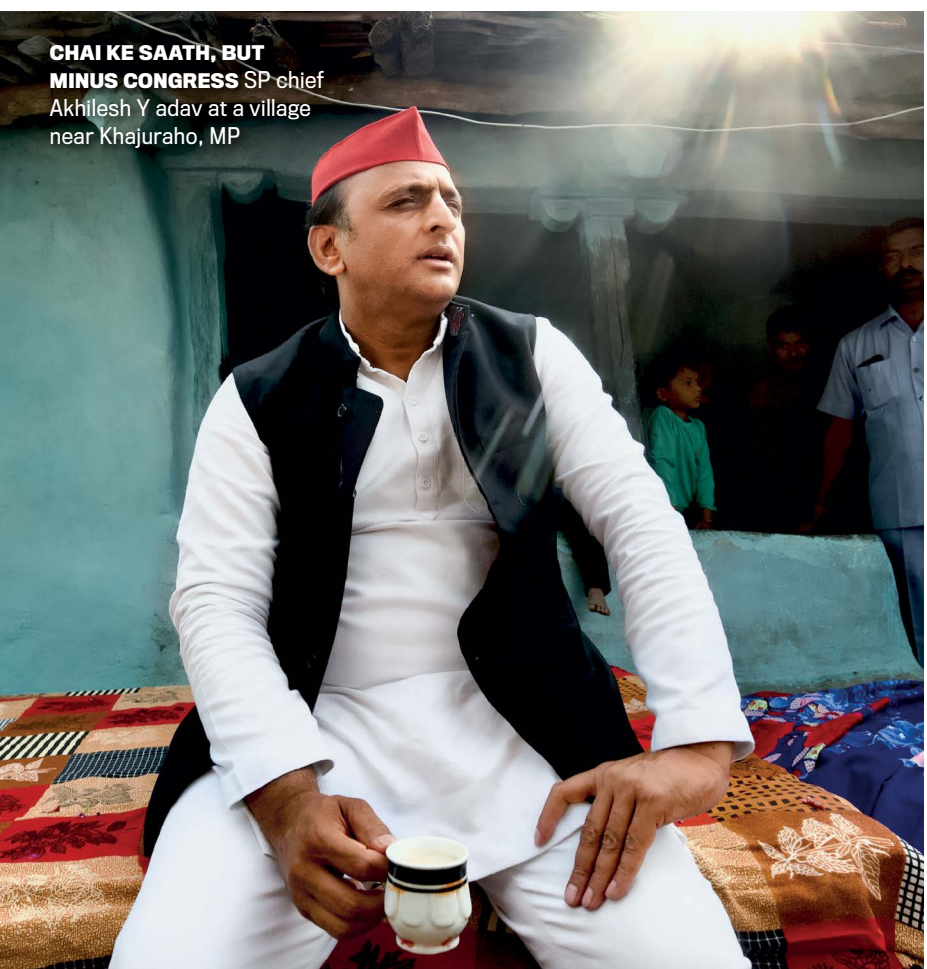
By Prashant Srivastava

The rift between two important members of the Opposition INDIA bloc, the Congress and the Samajwadi Party (SP), is assuming the proportions of a running feud. On November 5, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav called the Congress a *chaalu* (cunning) party and repeated the charge of 'betrayal' that he first made during the fracas over seat-sharing for the assembly polls in Madhya Pradesh. Addressing a rally in the Tikamgarh district of MP, Akhilesh said, "If you are not getting rations, why should you vote for the BJP? Don't vote for the Congress either; they are a very cunning party." As a fresh spat ensued, Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai accused the SP of disturbing the Congress campaign in MP.

Akhilesh had clearly initiated this fresh spell of hostility in full awareness and anticipation. On November 6, SP general secretary and three-time MP Ravi Verma was to join the Congress with daughter Purvi. A close aide of the late SP patriarch, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Verma claimed he found himself unable to work for the SP due to an "adverse internal party atmosphere" and alleged that a 'coterie' close to Akhilesh is ruining it. "We are impressed with the leadership and ideology of the Congress. We are thankful to the Samajwadi Party... but we were not feeling comfortable there. We can't compromise with our principles, which SP is lacking now," Purvi Verma tells INDIA TODAY. Ravi Verma, considered a prominent OBC leader, was elected from Lakhimpur Kheri district in the 1998, 1999 and 2004 Lok Sabha elections and was later elected as a Rajya Sabha member on the party's ticket. Verma's switch from the SP may be the tip of an iceberg—Congress leaders claim at least half a dozen senior SP leaders are in touch with the party.

Stung by the blow from Verma, a fuming SP is thinking of replying in kind. "The way Congress is poaching our party leaders...will damage the alliance. Though we were aware that Ravi Verma was in touch with the Congress leadership, we expected the Congress to not do anything that would harm the integrity of the alliance. Since they are doing that, they will also suffer the repercussions," says a senior SP leader.

It's not just about taking in disaffected SP leaders. Many of the Congress's programmes, too, are ranged against the SP. On November 6, the Grand Old Party's minority cell launched 'Congress ki baat, chai ke saath' (a chat about the party over a cup of tea). In a string of public meetings in minority-dominated areas, party leaders talk about not only the reasons for the attenuation of the Congress



CHAI KE SAATH, BUT MINUS CONGRESS SP chief Akhilesh Y adav at a village near Khajuraho, MP

HOT WORDS

- **At an election rally in MP, Akhilesh Yadav termed the Congress a "chalu" party**
- **On November 6, SP general secretary and ex-MP Ravi Verma joined the Congress**
- **Amid talk of more of its leaders joining the Congress, SP plans 'repercussions', prepares to contest LS polls in Uttar Pradesh by itself**